

The India Today Board assesses the implications of a possible army deployment to fight Maoists

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|  <p>BOARD OF EXPERTS ON SECURITY &amp; TERROR</p> <p><b>THE BEST VERDICT</b></p> |  <p><b>AJIT KUMAR DOVAL</b><br/>Former Director, Intelligence Bureau</p> <p><b>"A political decision to use the army is a fait accompli. But, it needs retooling security management in Naxal areas."</b></p> |  <p><b>MAJOR-GEN (RETD) V.K. DATTA</b><br/>Former DDG MO (Special Operations)</p> <p><b>"The paramilitary forces need better training, equipment, motivation and deployment in battalions, not as companies."</b></p> |  <p><b>G. PARTHASARATHY</b><br/>Former High Commissioner to Pakistan</p> <p><b>"The PM must involve the CMs of Maoist-infected states to establish civil administration and effective development."</b></p> |  <p><b>AIR VICE-MARSHAL (RETD) KAPIL KAK</b><br/>Addnl Director, Centre for Air Power Studies</p> <p><b>"The defeat of the Maoists demands resolve and patience for a campaign that could stretch to a decade."</b></p> |  <p><b>AJAI SAHNI</b><br/>Executive Director, Centre for Conflict Studies</p> <p><b>"If the army is sent in, it won't be a quick in-and-out deployment. It will remain trapped in a protracted conflict."</b></p> |  <p><b>LT-GENERAL SATISH NAMBIAR</b><br/>Former deputy chief of the army staff</p> <p><b>"The army has been deployed in J&amp;K and North-eastern states that have secessionist motives. Maoists haven't shown any."</b></p> |
| <p><b>SHOULD THE ARMY BE CALLED IN?</b></p>                                                                                                                       | <p>● Yes. But only if certain conditions are met. Army strengths are manpower and IED clearance. The negatives include having no knowledge of the terrain.</p>                                                                                                                                 | <p>● No. Deploy the army only for advisory, training and logistics support. If all other options fail raise fresh RR battalions instead of more paramilitary battalions.</p>                                                                                                                           | <p>● No. But send in small army airmobile special forces units to target Maoist leaders. Replace the IPS with army officers skilled in counter-insurgency.</p>                                                                                                                               | <p>● No. The army is over-stretched and has little spare capacities. Drawing it in would blunt its war-fighting capabilities and erode its discipline and moral ethos.</p>                                                                                                                                | <p>● No, it is the last resort. But all else has not been tried yet. The Government is looking for quick outcomes when it should look at a protracted war framework.</p>                                                                                                                             | <p>● No. The Government must declare local emergencies to conduct anti-Maoist operations in affected districts using paramilitary forces. Use armed forces as a backup.</p>                                                                                                                                     |

on stand-by. The Maoists are wresting the upper hand in their war against the state. In a series of strikes against security forces this year, 170 security personnel have been killed in the past five months, including 75 Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) personnel in a single ambush in Dantewada on April 6; 351 civilians have lost their lives too. Sustained attacks on railway tracks have seen derailling of eight trains and led to the death of 148 train passengers in a single attack by Maoist affiliates on May 28 in West Midnapore district. The 65 battalions of Central paramilitary forces (CPMFs), in addition to local state police and state armed police, have proved inadequate in containing the Maoists. The debate has now shifted to whether this force needs to be aug-

mented by more CPMFs or by the regular army. Military officials say it is now a question of when rather than if the army will be deployed. "Another incident like Dantewada will be the tripwire. We will be forced to move in," says a general.

With Maoist attacks getting deadlier and their tactics more ruthless, the initiative has slipped out of the hands of Home Minister P. Chidambaram. With his aggressive strategy coming into question within the Government and the prime minister taking a personal interest in the issue, Chidambaram is now waiting for a mid-course review by the CCS. It could opt for a tougher approach—by calling in the army—or a more humane one by focusing on development of the affected regions.

Home ministry officials, meanwhile, are sticking to their stand. "The strategy is definitely working. We just need to keep tuning and fine-tuning it," said Home Secretary G.K. Pillai.

It would seem the flare-up in central India is inversely proportional to a climbdown of violence in J&K—2010 was the quietest year in a two-decade insurgency. From over 4,500 fatalities in 2001, it declined to less than 400 last year and militancy-related incidents showed a 37 per cent decline. Last year, the army moved out two divisions from the northern state to peacetime locations but has shown an extreme reluctance to disturb a carefully constructed counter-insurgency grid. One of those who have dug their heels over redeploying the army has been